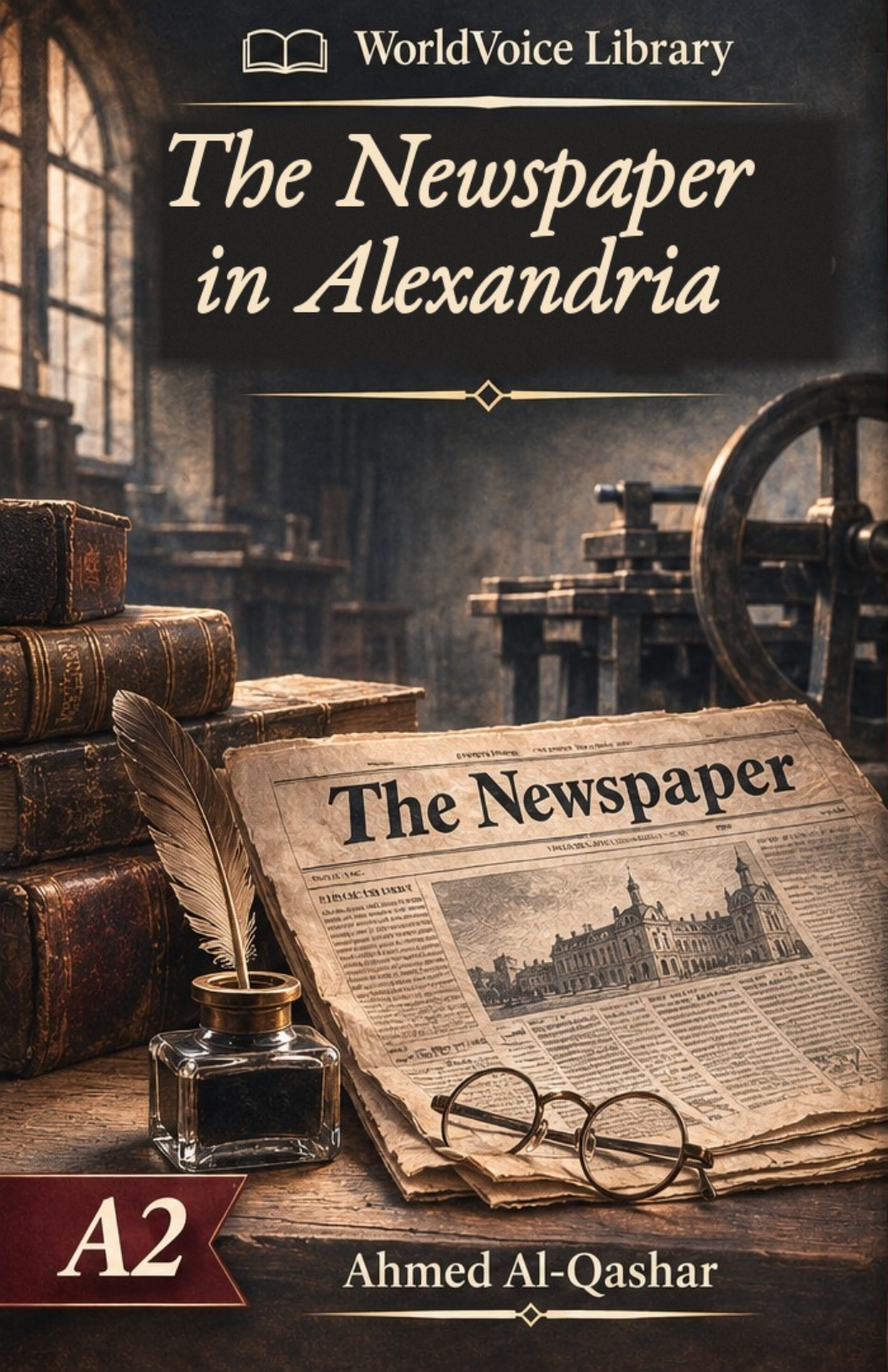
WorldVoice Library

The Newspaper in Alexandria



A2

Ahmed Al-Qashar

The Newspaper in Alexandria

A Story in Alexandria, Egypt · 1919

By Ahmed Al-Qashar

WorldVoice Library
English Graded Readers · Level A2

Publication & Rights

The Newspaper in Alexandria is an original fictional graded reader for WorldVoice Library. Written by Ahmed Al-Qashar.

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This story takes place in Alexandria in 1919. The characters, the newspaper, the reading room, and the local documents in the story are fictional. They are not historical claims about identifiable people.

Historical background: in 1919 Egypt experienced a nationwide movement for independence, and newspapers were an important means of sharing news. The story avoids treating fictional details as confirmed historical events.

Editorial learning edition for English A2 (Elementary). The CEFR level is an intended reading level, not an independent certification.

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Before You Read

A small newspaper. A blue door. One important question.

This story is about a young newspaper worker in Alexandria, Egypt, in 1919. A letter arrives at his office. It says that a public reading room may soon close. He wants to help, but a newspaper must check the facts before it prints them.

Think About It

1. Why do people read newspapers?

2. What can happen when someone publishes a story without checking it?

3. Why might a small reading room be important to a neighborhood?

Key Words Before Reading

• press — a machine that prints words on paper

• reporter — a person who finds and writes news

• fact — something that is true and can be checked

• notice — a written message in a public place

Characters



Youssef

A nineteen-year-old newspaper worker who wants to become a reporter. He carries a little notebook.



Mariam

A young reporter who asks clear questions and checks different sources.

Leila

A careful typesetter who puts metal letters together to print the words.



Mr. Adil

The editor and owner of The Alexandria Morning. He believes that facts matter.

Miss Safiya

A teacher who runs the Harbor Reading Room behind a blue wooden door.

Mr. Nassar

A representative of a trading company who believes it can use a building on Harbor Street.

Um Amina

A tea seller who remembers the reading room’s early days.

Mr. Bassem

The printer who knows the old printing machine better than anyone.

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CHAPTER 1

The Sound of the Press

The first thing Youssef heard every morning was not the sea. It was the printing press. The old machine stood in a narrow building near the harbor of Alexandria. When it worked well, it sounded like a train going over a bridge. When it worked badly, it sounded like a hungry animal.

Youssef was nineteen. His father sold fish near the water, and his mother made clothes for other families. They were proud that Youssef worked for a newspaper. They did not know that the newspaper had almost no money.

Every morning, before the streets became busy, Youssef walked past the bread shop and the tram stop. On clear days he could see the blue sea between the buildings. On windy days the air carried sand, salt, and the smell of wet rope.



The newspaper was called The Alexandria Morning. It was small. Some days it had only four pages. The owner and editor, Mr. Adil, wrote most of the articles. A young reporter called Mariam spoke to people in the streets. Leila worked with the metal letters that made the printed words. Mr. Bassem watched the press and repaired it when it broke.

Youssef carried paper, cleaned the tables, and delivered newspapers. He also wanted to write. In his pocket he kept a little notebook. He wrote down new words, questions, and things that other people did not notice.

On Monday he arrived early and found Leila standing beside a table full of tiny metal letters. She was looking for one letter under a pile of paper.

"Have you lost a whole sentence this time?" Youssef asked.

"Only the letter A," Leila said. "But without it, the name Alexandria becomes a very strange name. Help me look."

They searched the floor together. The letter was under Youssef's shoe. Leila laughed and held it up. "A newspaper must begin with the right letters," she said. "And it must finish with the right facts."

Mr. Adil came from his small office. He wore a dark jacket even when the room was warm. He had a pencil behind one ear and a long list of bills in his hand. He asked Youssef to take twenty newspapers to a cafe across the street.

"Can I write a story for tomorrow?" Youssef asked.

"What story?" said Mr. Adil.

"The price of bread is going up. People are talking about it."

"People talk about many things," the editor answered. "A reporter must ask why, and then ask again. Bring me names, dates, and more than one answer. After that, we can talk about your story."

Youssef nodded. He was disappointed, but he opened his notebook. Mr. Adil saw this and smiled a little. "That is a good beginning," he said.

Outside the cafe, men argued about the news. Women passed with baskets of food. A boy offered fresh oranges to anyone who would listen. A teacher stood by the door of a small reading room, helping a child sound out the words on a notice.

Youssef often passed this place. It had a blue wooden door, two windows, and a little sign: THE HARBOR READING ROOM. Inside were old books, newspapers, wooden benches, and a blackboard. Children studied there after work. Adults came in the evening to learn to read letters from their families.

The teacher, Miss Safiya, saw Youssef and waved. "Tell your editor we have twelve new readers this month," she said. "That is good news."

"I will," Youssef promised. He wrote it down beside the note about bread.

When he returned to the newspaper, a white envelope was lying under the front door. There was no name on it. Mr. Adil picked it up and opened it with a paper knife. A short message was written in careful handwriting.

THE HARBOR READING ROOM WILL CLOSE ON FRIDAY. THE BUILDING WILL BECOME A STOREHOUSE. THE PEOPLE HAVE NOT BEEN TOLD.

For a moment nobody spoke. Youssef looked at the little blue door through the window. Miss Safiya was still teaching a child how to read.

"We must print this," he said.

Mr. Adil folded the letter. "First," he said, "we must find out whether it is true."

CHAPTER 2

The Blue Door

The next morning, Youssef and Mariam went to the reading room. Mariam was twenty-three and had worked for the newspaper for three years. She walked quickly and asked direct questions. People sometimes thought she was too young to be a reporter. They usually changed their minds after five minutes.

The street outside the room was full of carts and bicycles. A man carried a wooden chair on his back. Two girls were waiting by the blue door with schoolbooks under their arms. Miss Safiya welcomed the visitors and offered them tea.

"We received a letter," Mariam explained. "It says this room will close on Friday. Have you heard anything?"



Miss Safiya's face changed. "A man came yesterday," she said. "He measured the outside wall. He would not tell me why. The room has been here longer than I have. My aunt studied here when she was young."

Mariam wrote the answer carefully. "Do you own the building?"

"No. A group of harbor workers helped open the room years ago. The city lets us use it. I have an old paper about it, but I do not know what all the words mean."

She went to a cupboard and returned with a brown envelope. Inside was a letter dated many years before. The ink was pale, and one corner had been damaged by water.

"It says something about a public room," Youssef said. "And about a time limit."

"Let us read every line before we decide what it means," Mariam replied.

They sat on a bench. Around them, children read quietly. On the other side of the room, a fisherman was learning to write his name. He shaped each letter slowly, as if it were a small boat he did not want to break.

Youssef looked up at the faces and the wooden shelves. He had never thought of a room as something that could be lost. A cup could break. A person could move away. But could a room disappear while its books and people were still there?

A tall man entered wearing a light suit. He said his name was Mr. Nassar and that he worked for a trading company. "You will have to leave soon," he told Miss Safiya. "The company needs this building."

"For what?" she asked.

"We need a place to keep goods from the port. The company has papers. It is official."

Mariam stood. "May we see those papers? We are from The Alexandria Morning."

Mr. Nassar looked unhappy. "I do not speak to newspapers," he said. "Newspapers make everything more difficult."

"We only want to know what will happen," Mariam answered. "The children have a right to know."

"Ask at the city office," he said. Then he left without drinking the tea Miss Safiya had prepared for him.

Youssef wanted to follow him. Mariam stopped him. "A fast question is not always a good question," she said. "We have a name now. We have a second source. We need the documents."

At the city office, the clerk told them that records could not be shown before the next morning. He pointed to a notice on the wall. It had the number 18 and the words HARBOR STREET. On another sheet the number was 81. Mariam noticed the difference but did not say anything.

"Do numbers change when a building becomes a storehouse?" Youssef whispered.

"No," she answered. "But people make mistakes. Do not call a mistake a crime."

They returned to the newspaper late in the afternoon. Mr. Adil listened and asked them to put the facts on separate lines. Miss Safiya had seen a man measuring the wall. Mr. Nassar said a company wanted the building. An old letter mentioned the public use of the

room. Two notices had different numbers. Those were the facts. Everything else was a question.

"So can we print the story?" Youssef asked.

"We can print that questions have been raised," said Mr. Adil. "We cannot yet print that someone has stolen a building. Words can hurt people. Be sure before you use them."

Leila set the first headline: QUESTIONS ABOUT THE BLUE DOOR. It was small but honest. Youssef watched the letters become lines of type. He had imagined that reporting was a way to tell people what to think. He was beginning to understand that it was a way to help them see what was known.

CHAPTER 3

The Missing Number

Wednesday began with rain. The streets were wet and bright, and the tram made a loud sound as it turned the corner. Youssef carried a dry cloth over his notebook. Mariam carried a large umbrella that seemed too small for two people.

At the city office they waited behind three men who wanted papers for their shops. A clerk with glasses sat at a high wooden desk. He took the old letter and looked at it for a long time.

"The Harbor Reading Room," he said at last. "There should be a record in the old book."



He opened a heavy ledger. The pages smelled of dust. Each page had a number. He turned to 18, then stopped.

"It is not here," he said.

Youssef felt his heart fall. "Does that mean the letter is false?"

"It means I have not found the page," the clerk answered. "People are very quick to decide what something means."

Mariam smiled. She had said almost the same thing the day before.

The clerk looked in another book and found a drawing of Harbor Street. The reading room stood between a small bakery and a repair shop. Across the street was an empty yard. On the plan, both places were marked with numbers.

"Look," Mariam said. "The room is building 18. The yard is building 81."

Youssef could hardly believe how much difference two little numbers could make. "Could the company want the yard?" he asked.

"Perhaps," the clerk said. "Or perhaps it wants both. We must see the agreement."

A woman entered with a basket of documents. She introduced herself as Mrs. Hanan, an assistant at the city archive. She knew the old street well. Her grandfather had worked near the harbor, and she remembered hearing about the reading room when she was a child.

"There were two agreements," she said. "One was for a public reading room. The other was for an empty piece of land. They were written in different years. Sometimes people put the wrong sheet in the wrong file."

She promised to look for the agreement after work. Mariam thanked her. Outside, Youssef said that he was sure they had solved the mystery.

"We have found a reason for the wrong number," Mariam answered. "We have not found the agreement. A reporter should be happy when a question gets smaller, not pretend that it has disappeared."

They visited the trading company. This time Mr. Nassar agreed to speak for ten minutes. His office was clean, and a large map of the harbor hung above his desk.

"The port is busy," he said. "We need room for supplies. I have workers waiting for jobs. If we cannot find storage, those men will have no work. Please write that too."

Mariam did. She asked whether he knew about the children in the reading room. He said yes, but he believed the building had been empty for several months.

"It is not empty," Youssef said. "We were there yesterday."

Mr. Nassar looked surprised. "Then someone has given me bad information," he said. "But I have already paid for the work to begin."

For the first time, Youssef saw that the story had more than one side. He disliked the thought of the reading room closing, but he could also understand the worry in the man's voice when he spoke about his workers.

That evening the team met around the editor's desk. Mr. Adil drew two columns on paper. One was titled WHAT WE KNOW. The other was titled WHAT WE STILL NEED. The second column was longer.

"A newspaper can make a small problem into a large fight," he said. "Or it can show people exactly where the problem is. We should choose the second road."

Leila brought them tea. "And we need the right numbers," she said. "Eighteen is not eighty-one."

Youssef wrote the sentence in his notebook. It looked simple. But that day it had opened a new door.

CHAPTER 4

An Empty Place on the Page

On Thursday, the printing press stopped in the middle of a sentence. It made a sharp noise, shook twice, and became silent. Bassem lifted the side cover and looked inside. Then he took off his cap and sat down on a box.

"The drive belt is broken," he said. "The machine has worked too hard for too many years."

"Can you repair it?" Youssef asked.



"Perhaps. I need a new belt and several hours. The shops may not have the right size."

The morning newspaper had not been finished. Half the papers were lying on a table. On one page was Mariam's article about the

reading room. On another was a blank space where an advertisement should have been.

Mr. Adil counted the money in a small tin. There was not enough for a new belt and the paper bill. There was not enough to pay everyone for the week. He put the coins back without speaking.

A messenger arrived with a letter from Mr. Nassar. The trading company offered to buy a large advertisement for the following month. The money would be useful. But the letter also asked the newspaper to stop writing about Harbor Street.

"He cannot tell us what to print," Mariam said.

"He can choose where to spend his money," Mr. Adil answered. "And we can choose what kind of newspaper we want to be. I do not like either choice today."

Leila read the letter. "Why don't we ask him to advertise his storehouse plans without any promise about our stories?" she suggested.

Mr. Adil nodded. "That would be fair. We can sell space. We cannot sell a decision."

Youssef went out to find a repair shop. He walked through streets where men discussed the future of Egypt and newspapers sold quickly. In 1919, many people in the country wanted changes. Some newspapers were careful about what they printed. Youssef knew that Mr. Adil sometimes left a line out of an article because the words might cause trouble. The little newspaper could not fight every battle.

At a workshop near the tram stop, a mechanic called Omar listened to the problem. "A belt for an old press?" he asked. "I have one, but it is used. It may work for a day or two."

"We only need tomorrow's paper," Youssef said.

Omar laughed. "Tomorrow always becomes the day after tomorrow. Take the belt. Pay me when you can."

Youssef carried it back carefully. In the office he found Mrs. Hanan waiting with a folder tied with string. She had discovered the public reading room agreement. It said that the building could be used for education and reading for a fixed number of years. The final year was 1925. The trading company had been offered the neighboring yard, not the reading room.

"Then it is settled!" Youssef cried.

"Not quite," Mrs. Hanan replied. "The agreement is old, and I must check that there are no later changes. The copy is clear, but we need the last record too."

Mr. Adil put the documents under a heavy book. "Tomorrow morning," he said. "We will print only what we can prove tonight."

They waited while Bassem fitted the belt. He moved a wheel by hand. The machine turned once, then twice. Leila prepared the type while Mariam checked the names and dates. After an hour Bassem pulled the handle. The press began to turn. Everyone cheered.

But Youssef noticed that the headline on the first sheet was missing a word. It read: ROOM WILL CLOSE ON FRIDAY. Mariam's careful word MAY had fallen out of the line.

"Stop the machine!" he shouted. "That is not what we wrote."

Bassem stopped it at once. Mr. Adil examined the page and looked at Youssef. "You were right," he said. "One small word can make a great difference."

Leila put the missing letters back. They printed fewer papers that morning, but the words were correct. Youssef understood why the editor had told him to ask twice before writing once. A machine could make a thousand copies of a mistake in one hour.

CHAPTER 5

A Woman by the Sea Wall

The wind came from the sea on Friday. It pushed water against the old stone wall and carried the smell of boats into the streets. Youssef found Mariam near the harbor, speaking to an elderly woman named Um Amina. The woman sold tea from a little stall and had lived near Harbor Street all her life.

"I remember the first books," Um Amina said. "My brother carried them in a wooden box. My mother gave a few coins when the room opened. We had little money, but we wanted our children to read."

"Do you remember who owned the building?" Mariam asked.



"The city owned it. But people gave money to repair the roof and buy benches. My father was one of them. There is a list of names somewhere."

Youssef showed her the old agreement. Her fingers rested on one line. "That is my father's name," she said. "Hassan Farouk. He could not read when he was young. He did not want his children to grow up the same way."

The woman asked them to sit. She gave them tea and told them about the opening day. A small band had played in the street. Children had carried paper flags. The door was painted blue because someone had a pot of blue paint left after repairing a boat.

"There was no great plan," she said. "Just people doing a small thing together. Small things can last longer than anyone expects."

Youssef listened. He had gone there to find a useful fact. He found a story about a family he had never met, and about a place where his own mother might have learned to read if she had been young at the right time.

Mariam asked whether Um Amina would allow her name to appear in the paper. The woman said yes. "But do not make me sound like a hero," she said. "The teacher is the hero. And the people who keep going there."

At the room, Miss Safiya was moving books away from a wet window. Rain had come through a crack in the frame. The children helped her carry the books to a dry shelf. Two men from the company stood outside with measuring tools, but they did not enter.

"Is this the last day?" asked a little girl called Lina. She was holding a book about ships.

"I don't know," said Miss Safiya. "We will keep reading until someone tells us we cannot."

Youssef knelt beside Lina. "What is your favorite word in the book?"

"Harbor," she said. "It is the place where ships come home."

He put her answer in his notebook. It was not evidence about the building. It was something else: a reason to care about the evidence.

Later that day they returned to Mr. Nassar's office with the old agreement. He studied it and asked for time. "If this is the right paper," he said, "my company has been given the wrong place. I have already paid people to prepare it. I want a fair answer too."

Mariam did not promise him a good story. She promised him an accurate one. They agreed to meet a city officer the following morning. The officer would compare the company's documents with the archive record.

Back at the newspaper, the team talked for a long time. Mr. Adil wanted to write about Um Amina, the teacher, and the children, but not turn Mr. Nassar into a villain. The man had strong reasons to want a storehouse. The truth might be that an office had confused two properties.

"Readers will want a simple enemy," Youssef said.

"Sometimes the story is not simple," Mariam answered. "That does not give us permission to make it simple by changing the facts."

Before leaving, Youssef stood alone by the press. The machine was silent, but he imagined tomorrow's pages passing under its rollers. He had wanted to become famous for writing a story. Now he wanted the story to help people understand what was happening.

CHAPTER 6

The Price of Paper

Saturday was supposed to bring answers. Instead it brought another bill. The paper supplier sent a note saying that The Alexandria Morning must pay its debt before receiving more paper. There were only three rolls left in the store.

Mr. Adil read the note twice. "If we use all our paper today, we may have nothing on Monday," he said.

"If we do not print today, people will not hear what we have found," Mariam answered.



Bassem rubbed his hands. They were dark with ink. "A press cannot print on air," he said. "Not even this old machine."

Leila suggested making a smaller newspaper: two pages instead of four. That would save paper and ink. Mr. Adil agreed, but he

worried about the workers. "A smaller paper does not mean smaller meals for our families," he said.

Youssef offered to carry the remaining papers to shops and ask for payment in advance. At the first shop, the owner gave him money but asked why the newspaper had become thinner. Youssef told him about the debt and the broken machine.

"Then you need readers, not just customers," the shopkeeper said. "Explain what is happening. People cannot help with a problem they do not know about."

Youssef thought about these words as he walked. At the reading room he found Miss Safiya teaching a group of adults. One man held The Alexandria Morning and read a headline aloud. When he made a mistake, the others corrected him gently.

"They practice with your newspaper," Miss Safiya said. "Even when the stories are difficult, they like to see the words used in real life."

Youssef told her about the smaller edition. She brought a small wooden box from behind her desk. It held coins collected for pencils and books. "We cannot give you the children's money," she said, "but I will buy a month's newspapers with my own wages."

"I did not come here to ask for money," he said quickly.

"I know. I want to read a paper that asks questions, not a paper that only prints what rich people want to say."

At the city office, Mrs. Hanan and a senior clerk compared the documents. The numbers had indeed been changed on one map. Building 18 was the reading room. Building 81 was the empty yard. The company had received permission to inspect the yard, not to

take the reading room. The workers measuring the walls had used the wrong plan.

Mr. Nassar stood beside them and read the papers. At last he put down his hat. "This is an expensive mistake," he said. "But I see it now. My company needs a yard, not an argument with children."

The officer promised to send a corrected notice on Monday. Until then, no work would begin at either place. Mariam asked permission to copy the relevant lines. She also asked the official to explain them in simple language so readers would understand.

As they left, Mr. Nassar stopped Youssef. "I spoke badly to you," he said. "I thought the newspaper wanted to make me look foolish."

"We wanted to understand the papers," Youssef answered. "At first, we did not understand them either."

Mr. Nassar looked toward the port. "I still need a storehouse," he said. "Perhaps I can use the yard next to the room. Perhaps the workers there can help us build it. The two places do not have to be enemies."

Youssef returned to the press with good news and an idea. "Let us print the documents, and also explain why the newspaper is in trouble. We should tell readers the truth about ourselves."

Mr. Adil did not answer immediately. A newspaper usually wrote about other people's problems, not its own. But he finally nodded. "We will print the facts of the building case on the front page," he said. "And our small note about the paper on the last page. No begging. No promises we cannot keep. Just the truth."

Leila carefully set the headline: TWO BUILDINGS, TWO NUMBERS. Beneath it she placed the simple map Mariam had

drawn. Youssef checked every letter of the street name before the press began to turn.

The new edition was thinner. It was also the first newspaper Youssef had helped make from the beginning of the story to the final printed page. He held the warm paper in his hands and felt proud, not because it was perfect, but because it was honest.

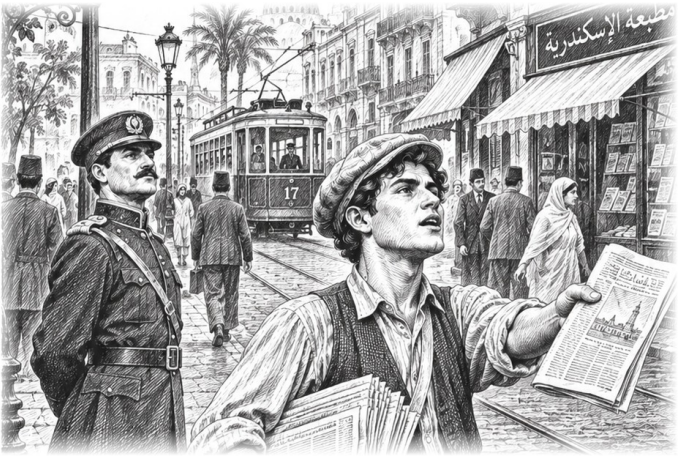
CHAPTER 7

The Morning Crowd

On Sunday morning, the street outside the newspaper was crowded before Youssef arrived. A baker stood near a sailor. A teacher waited beside a young mother. Three children were trying to read the headline on a paper pinned to the wall.

Youssef thought there had been an accident. Then he saw the box beside the door. Someone had painted a sign on it: KEEP THE MORNING PAPER GOING. Inside were small coins and folded notes.

"Who put that there?" he asked.



Leila came outside with a cup of tea. "I do not know," she said. "Bassem found it when he opened the door. The first person came at sunrise."

A man from the bakery held up his newspaper. "You printed the street numbers," he said. "Now everyone understands. I had thought the building belonged to the company."

"I had thought the company wanted to close a school," said another. "But it was a mistake in a map. It is good that we waited for the papers."

Not everyone was pleased. A visitor complained that the newspaper should have blamed someone. "A story without a bad man is not exciting," he said.

"It can still be important," Mariam replied. "The children can keep their room. That matters more than an exciting name in a headline."

Miss Safiya arrived carrying a list of new subscriptions. She had asked people at the reading room whether they wanted the newspaper delivered each week. Some bought one paper for a whole family. Others paid for a copy to stay on the reading room table. It was not much money, but it was enough to make Mr. Adil smile.

A boy who sold oranges came through the crowd. "I want to sell the paper too," he told Youssef. "People buy oranges because they are hungry. Sometimes they are hungry for news."

"First you must learn to say the headlines clearly," Youssef said.

The boy tried: "TWO BUILDINGS, TWO... TWO..."

"NUMBERS," said Lina, who was standing nearby. She sounded proud. Everyone laughed, and the boy repeated the full headline.

By noon, the street had become quiet again. Mr. Adil counted the donations and the new orders. The money would pay part of the debt and buy another roll of paper. It would not make the newspaper rich. But it would give the workers time to plan.

"We cannot ask our readers to save us every month," the editor said. "We must make a paper they want to buy because it is useful."

Mariam suggested a weekly page about schools, prices, streets, and ordinary workers. Leila wanted a short box explaining difficult words. Bassem wanted a notice about repairs, because people often did not know where to find good tools. Even Youssef had an idea: a small space for questions from readers, with answers checked by the reporters.

"You have become a writer after all," Mr. Adil told him.

"Not yet," Youssef replied. "I still have too many questions."

"That is exactly why you may become one," the editor said.

In the afternoon Youssef went to the reading room. The blue door was open. A new notice had been placed inside the window: THE ROOM WILL REMAIN OPEN. A group of children were reading a story about a traveler who reached home after many days at sea.

Lina saw Youssef. "I can read your name in the paper now," she said. She pointed to a small line at the end of Mariam's article: Reporting assistance: Youssef Nabil.

He had not known that his name was there. He looked at it for a long time. It was a very small line, but it meant more to him than a large picture of himself would have meant.

CHAPTER 8

The Last Question

On Monday the official notice arrived at the reading room. It said that building 18 would stay in public use under the old agreement. The company could ask to rent building 81, the empty yard, after the normal checks. The letter also asked the reading room to repair its roof before the winter rains.

"So everything is finished," Youssef said when he heard the news.

"Not quite," Miss Safiya replied. "We still need to fix the roof, pay for new books, and keep the doors open every day. A good ending does not mean there is no more work."



Youssef had come to understand this answer. It was the same with the newspaper. The press worked today, but it might break

tomorrow. Readers had paid for this month, but they might choose a different paper next month. Good things needed care.

Mariam asked him to go with her to see Mr. Nassar one last time. The trading company had received the corrected documents and could now plan to use the empty yard. Several workers were measuring it. They had also been told not to touch the reading room wall.

Mr. Nassar came out to speak to them. "I read your story," he said. "You wrote my answers fairly. I did not expect that."

"A fair story is the only kind we want to write," Mariam answered. "May we ask one more question?"

He laughed. "Reporters always have one more question."

"Will the new storehouse make more noise on Harbor Street? The teacher says the children need quiet in the afternoons."

The businessman looked toward the blue door. "That is a reasonable question," he said. "We can move the heavy carts to the other entrance. I will speak to the workers."

Youssef wrote down the promise but did not write that it was already a fact. A promise was a promise. They would come back and see what happened.

On the way to the newspaper, the two reporters passed the sea wall. Um Amina was selling tea from her little stall. She held up the latest edition and pointed to her father's name in the story. "My father would have laughed," she said. "He never liked attention."

"Then perhaps he would like the final line," Mariam said. She showed her the words: The reading room was built by many hands, and many hands will keep it open.

Um Amina read the line slowly. Her eyes filled with tears, but she was smiling. "That is true," she said. "That is the part I want people to remember."

Back at the office, Mr. Adil was checking the accounts. The new subscriptions had helped, but the paper still needed work. He asked Youssef to write a short article about the roof repairs. "It is not a famous subject," he said, "but it is a useful one."

Youssef spent the afternoon asking questions. He spoke to a carpenter about wood, a shopkeeper about nails, and Miss Safiya about money. He wrote a clear article with short sentences and a list of what the room needed. He did not call anyone a hero. He did not promise that a new roof would appear by magic.

When Mr. Adil read the article, he crossed out two words and changed one number. Then he gave it back. "This can be printed," he said.

Youssef looked at the changes. His first real article was not perfect. He had expected to feel sad about the corrections, but instead he felt relieved. Someone had read his work carefully. Together they had made it better.

"One more question," he said.

Mr. Adil raised his eyebrows. "Of course."

"Will you teach me how to write the headline too?"

The editor placed a clean sheet of paper on the desk. "Sit down," he said. "We will begin with the words that matter most."

CHAPTER 9

Another First Page

A week after the white envelope appeared, the newspaper office smelled of fresh paper again. The press had a new belt, the bills were smaller, and the workers had decided to make a new page for the readers of Alexandria.

Leila placed the type in careful lines. Bassem checked the rollers. Mariam had returned from an interview with a woman who repaired fishing nets. Mr. Adil was reading a letter from a schoolteacher who wanted the newspaper to explain how local decisions were made.

Youssef sat at the small desk by the window. His notebook was open. On the first page he had written a list of questions from the day when the envelope arrived. On the last page he wrote another list. He had many more questions now, but they were better questions.



He was working on an article about the reading room roof. The first headline he had written was THE CHILDREN NEED HELP. Mr. Adil said it was true but too general. After speaking to the carpenter, Youssef had found a clearer one: A NEW ROOF FOR THE BLUE DOOR.

"That is better," the editor said. "People can see what is needed."

Before the paper went to print, Mr. Nassar arrived. He was carrying a small package. Inside were a set of nails and a note from one of his workers. The worker had offered to help repair the reading room roof on his free day.

"I did not tell him to do it," Mr. Nassar said. "He read your article and made his own decision."

Youssef thanked him. He was pleased that the article had helped without asking anyone to feel ashamed. The little newspaper had done something useful simply by telling the truth clearly.

In the afternoon, Miss Safiya brought four children to visit the press. The children stood at a safe distance and watched the machine work. It made its old sound: a train on a bridge, a hungry animal, a hundred hands clapping together.

"Is that how words get into the paper?" Lina asked.

Leila showed her a tray of metal letters. "First we make the words carefully," she said. "Then the press makes copies."

"What happens if a word is wrong?" the girl asked.

Youssef smiled. "We stop and correct it. That is the most important part."

He took a clean sheet from the finished pile and showed the visitors the front page. It held Mariam's article about fishing nets, his article about the reading room, and a short note about the correct address for the new storehouse. At the bottom was a small box titled QUESTIONS FROM OUR READERS.

The first question came from a child. It asked why some streets had two different names. The answer was short, honest, and followed by a promise to find out more about the old name next week. Youssef liked that they did not pretend to know everything.

At sunset he carried the last copies to the cafe. The sea was calm. The streets shone with late golden light. Men talked at tables, families walked toward home, and a little boy tried to sell his final oranges.

The blue door of the reading room was still open. Inside, a woman who had never read a newspaper before was following the letters with her finger. Miss Safiya sat beside her. Neither looked up when Youssef passed. They were busy with a sentence.

He stopped at the corner and turned back toward the newspaper office. It was a small building, and its windows were dark now. Nothing about it looked important. The city had taller buildings, richer shops, and greater machines. Yet every morning a little light came on inside, and people worked to put true words on paper.

Youssef had once believed that a newspaper was simply a place where news was printed. He knew more now. It was a place where people listened, checked, changed their minds, and tried again. It could make mistakes. It could also correct them.

He took out his notebook and wrote one final sentence: A good newspaper does not open every door, but it can help people find the right one.

The next morning, he would begin another story.

Vocabulary (40 Words)

01. press *(n.)* — machine used to print text or pictures

02. newspaper *(n.)* — printed pages with news and information

03. reporter *(n.)* — a person who finds and writes news

04. editor *(n.)* — a person who checks and prepares writing

05. article *(n.)* — a piece of writing in a newspaper

06. headline *(n.)* — the title above a news story

07. notebook *(n.)* — a small book for writing notes

08. envelope *(n.)* — paper cover used to send a letter

09. harbor *(n.)* — a protected place for ships

10. reading room *(n.)* — a place where people can read and study

Vocabulary - Continued

11. notice *(n.)* — a short public message

12. measure *(v.)* — to find the size or length of something

13. company *(n.)* — a business organization

14. clerk *(n.)* — a person who keeps records in an office

15. document *(n.)* — a written or printed record

16. record *(n.)* — information kept for future use

17. mistake *(n.)* — something done incorrectly

18. source *(n.)* — a person or document that gives information

19. fact *(n.)* — something that can be checked as true

20. question *(n.)* — a sentence asking for information

Vocabulary - Continued

21. **answer** *(n.)* — a reply to a question

22. **correct** *(v.)* — to change what is wrong

23. **public** *(adj.)* — for everyone to use or see

24. **private** *(adj.)* — belonging to one person or organization

25. **agreement** *(n.)* — a decision accepted by different sides

26. **rent** *(v.)* — to pay money to use a place

27. **wall** *(n.)* — a strong side of a building or room

28. **yard** *(n.)* — an open area beside a building

29. **cafe** *(n.)* — a small place to buy drinks or food

30. **promise** *(n.)* — words saying that you will do something

Vocabulary - Continued

31. **repair** *(v.)* — to make a broken thing work again

32. **roof** *(n.)* — the top covering of a building

33. **paper** *(n.)* — material used for writing and printing

34. **ink** *(n.)* — colored liquid used to print or write

35. **letter** *(n.)* — a written message sent to someone

36. **publish** *(v.)* — to make writing available to readers

37. **truth** *(n.)* — what is real and correct

38. **fair** *(adj.)* — honest and reasonable to everyone

39. **subscription** *(n.)* — payment for regular copies of a newspaper

40. **community** *(n.)* — people who live or work in the same area

Comprehension Questions

1. Where does Youssef work, and what does he want to become?

2. What message is in the white envelope?

3. Why does Mr. Adil refuse to print the letter immediately?

4. Who works at the Harbor Reading Room?

5. What is unusual about the two building numbers?

6. What does Mariam tell Youssef about a mistake and a crime?

7. Why does the small newspaper need money?

8. How do the workers check the old agreement?

9. What finally happens to the blue-door reading room?

10. What lesson does Youssef learn about writing headlines?

True or False

1. Youssef is already a famous reporter at the start. T / F

2. Leila works with metal letters. T / F

3. Mariam believes that every claim must be checked. T / F

4. The reading room has a blue wooden door. T / F

5. Mr. Nassar agrees to speak to the reporters immediately. T / F

6. The two addresses are written with the same number. T / F

7. The newspaper never makes mistakes. T / F

8. The public reading room is important to local children and adults. T / F

9. The story ends with Youssef learning to ask better questions. T / F

10. The story says a good reporter must know everything. T / F

Choose the Best Answer

1. What does Youssef carry in his pocket?

a) A small notebook

b) A camera

c) A gold watch

2. Who is the editor?

a) Mr. Bassem

b) Mr. Adil

c) Mr. Nassar

3. What is the first important message about?

a) A missing ship

b) A broken bridge

c) A reading room that may close

4. Why do the reporters visit city records?

a) To find documents

b) To buy paper

c) To meet an artist

5. What does Youssef learn to do?

a) Ignore mistakes

b) Check facts and correct errors

c) Write only good news

6. Which sentence best describes the theme?

a) Truth needs careful work

b) Every promise is already a fact

c) Old buildings have no value

Discussion Questions

1. Would you have printed the anonymous letter immediately? Why?

2. Why is it important to ask more than one person?

3. What could Youssef do if the editor was wrong?

4. How can one small reading room help a neighborhood?

5. Which character is most careful? Give an example.

6. What is the difference between a fact and a promise?

7. How does the story show that correcting a mistake is useful?

8. What would you write in a newspaper about your community?

Writing Task

Write a short newspaper report of **120–150 words** about a useful change in your school, neighborhood, or town. You may invent the details.

Use these steps:

1. Write a clear headline.
2. Explain who, what, where, and when.
3. Give two facts and name their sources.
4. Include one question that is not yet answered.
5. Check your facts, spelling, and numbers.

Useful phrases: According to… / The teacher said… / The newspaper checked… / The next step will be…

Language Practice

A. Past simple: Complete each sentence with the correct verb form.

1. Youssef _____ (walk) past the harbor every morning.

2. Mariam _____ (ask) Miss Safiya a careful question.

3. They _____ (find) two different building numbers.

4. Mr. Adil _____ (read) the article twice.

5. Leila _____ (put) the metal letters in order.

B. Put these events in the correct order.

1. The reporters check the records.

2. A white envelope arrives.

3. Youssef writes his first article.

4. They visit the blue-door reading room.

5. The paper publishes a careful report.

Final Test

Part A – Select the correct answer.

1. Where does the story take place?
a) Alexandria b) London c) Rio de Janeiro

2. Who works at the reading room?
a) Leila b) Miss Safiya c) Agnes

3. What color is the door?
a) Red b) Green c) Blue

4. What problem does the city record show?
a) Two different building numbers b) A ship is missing c) A book is stolen

5. What is a reporter expected to do?
a) Guess quickly b) Check information c) Hide mistakes

6. Who sets the metal letters?
a) Leila b) Mariam c) Mr. Nassar

7. What is Youssef's notebook used for?
a) Cooking recipes only b) Writing questions and notes c) Drawing maps of Europe

8. What does the editor help Youssef improve?
a) His headline b) His coat c) His shoes

Final Test – Continued

Part B – Short answers.

1. Why is the reading room important?

2. Why does the anonymous letter need checking?

3. How do the characters solve the address problem?

4. What does Youssef learn about a published mistake?

5. Give one example of a promise that is not yet a fact.

Answer Key

True or False:

1 F · 2 T · 3 T · 4 T · 5 F · 6 F · 7 F · 8 T · 9 T · 10 F

Choose the Best Answer:

1 a · 2 b · 3 c · 4 a · 5 b · 6 a

Language Practice A:

1 walked · 2 asked · 3 found · 4 read · 5 put

Language Practice B:

Correct sequence by item number: 2 → 4 → 1 → 5 → 3

Final Test, Part A:

1 a · 2 b · 3 c · 4 a · 5 b · 6 a · 7 b · 8 a

Short answers examples:

1. It helps children and adults learn to read and gives people a place to study.

2. The letter has no name, so the reporters need documents and other people to confirm it.

3. They compare the old agreement and the city records to check the right building.

4. A mistake should be corrected clearly and carefully, not hidden.

5. Mr. Nassar says the heavy carts can use a different entrance; the reporters still need to check that it happens.

About This Story

The Newspaper in Alexandria is historical fiction. The newspaper, the reading room, and all main characters are invented. The story takes place in the wider setting of Egypt in 1919, a year of national protest and public debate. It focuses on everyday work, responsible journalism, education, and the value of checking information before publishing it.

For teachers and learners: The text is intended for A2 English reading practice. The glossary, comprehension questions, and writing task support independent reading or guided classroom use.

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The Newspaper in Alexandria

This graded reader includes:

- A compelling and realistic story
- Nine illustrated chapters
- A glossary of key vocabulary (40 words)
- Comprehension and discussion questions
- A writing task

English Level
A2
Elementary



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